

Who needs a Boot?!

On 19th March of this year, Phoenix announced a software that enables notebook users to access their Outlook data without booting their PCs. FirstWare Assistant is an example of how the company wants to extend the features of the traditional BIOS and replace it with its CSS.

It's installed as an Outlook plugin. Before exiting the e-mail software, the software saves the most recent status of contacts, calendar and e-mails in a file that can be accessed in pre-boot state. So instead of booting the system, you will be able to launch the FirstWare Assistant upon system start and access the file within a few seconds.

versial 'Palladium' scheme — now renamed Next-Generation Secure Computing Base—for building copy-protection and security features tied directly to computer hardware.

The company is marketing the TrustedCore NB BIOS to laptop system designers and contract manufacturers, and it's expected that IBM is a likely customer. Fujitsu and Samsung, too, have endorsed the technology.

The next evil empire?

If EFI-based software is accepted broadly, it

could prompt the first major change in pre-boot software in the history of the PC industry—even though some critics say the transition may take a while, or may not even happen at all. But Microsoft will support EFI in Longhorn. Intel will support the technology in future chipsets.

However, not everyone is jumping on the EFI bandwagon. Historically, PC makers have been reluctant to change. Also, some companies might see EFI as a way for Intel and Microsoft to push their own ideas for the future of PC design.

Intel says such suspicions are unfounded—companies that decide to go with EFI will be able to use it any way they like, by picking and choosing different features. EFI users don't necessarily have to work directly with Intel, either. They can work with companies such as Insyde, for example, or use technology developed by the forum, once it gets started.

In the meanwhile, Phoenix's plans have been criticised as crippling PCs' capabilities, solidifying the Microsoft OS monopoly and even, in cases where DRM is introduced, extending copyright holders' power into areas that have traditionally remained under the control of consumers.

Although EFI may take several years to get up to speed, Intel chipsets will offer the Framework as an alternative to a BIOS in 2005. The company's chipsets will support BIOS software for many years longer. However, as time passes, some chipset features may be accessible only via EFI.

"After 23 years, it was time to start from scratch," said Intel's Richmond. "There's a certain life-span for every technology. You can expand it and grow it, but at some point you will have to start over." 

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